

Tervapata (Tar Pot)

Overview:

A classic Finnish circle-running game played outdoors. Players stand along a drawn perimeter, watching the center, while a runner circles behind them with a stick or stone. The objective is to react quickly when the object is dropped and race around the circle to claim an open spot.

Setup:

- Players stand on assigned spots along a drawn circle, facing inward toward a central "tar pot."
- One player is chosen as the runner (kiertäjä) and starts outside the circle holding the object.

Gameplay:

1. Dropping the Object

- The runner walks or jogs around the outside of the circle behind the other players.
- Standing players must keep their eyes forward and are not allowed to look behind them until the runner passes.
- The runner secretly drops the object into a player's spot and continues running in the same direction.

2. The Race

- The player whose spot receives the object must pick it up and instantly run around the circle in the opposite direction of the runner.
- Both players race to reach the now-empty spot first.
- Whichever player reaches the spot first claims it and stands safely.
- The slower player without a spot becomes the new runner.

3. Sent to the Tar Pot

A player is penalized and must step into the central tar pot if they:

- Peek or look behind themselves before the runner passes.
- Fail to notice the object dropped in their spot.
- Allow the runner to complete a full lap and return to their spot before they start running.

4. Escaping the Tar Pot

- A trapped player remains in the tar pot until another player breaks a rule and takes their place, or
- After the role of the runner has changed hands three times.